the Republic Day celebrations in Lhasa earlier that year, six to eight bombers along with two squadrons of fighter jets had reportedly participated in the flypast.

By 1962, the imbalance of troops in the Western Sector was a major concern and the use of offensive air support to redress the balance was discussed as early as May. In fact, in a meeting chaired by Krishna Menon on 18 September, Army HQ was in favour of pulling back all available troops for the defence of Leh, but this would have meant abandoning the airfield at Chushul and large tracts of Ladakh—something that the then Chief of Air Staff, Air Marshal Aspy Engineer, vehemently opposed. In turn, the IAF offered to fly in reinforcements and provide interdiction missions against targets in West Tibet in the event of any troop concentrations. The Intelligence Bureau was asked to make a fresh assessment of the Chinese air strength, and the quantum of force that could be brought to bear against India.

The IB's assessment of the Chinese air offensive capability knocked the wind out of any offensive plans the IAF might have had. Mullik in his book claims that accurate intelligence about the PLAAF was passed on to Service HQ even before the 18 September meeting. Despite the withdrawal of support by the USSR, the IB felt that the PLAAF, operating from bases in Tibet, Yunnan and even Sinkiang, would have the run of the subcontinent, their bombers could even get to Madras as the IAF had a paucity of night interceptors. Besides, Chinese MiG-17s and 19s plus the newly acquired MiG-21s would wreak havoc on the Indian Canberra bombers because they all had night capability. The final twist to the projected horror story was that Pakistan was also planning to strike at Kashmir the moment hostilities broke out between India and China.

There were major flaws in what Mullik and the IB were saying. We have already noted that there were no advanced runways for the PLAAF to operate from, especially low-altitude runways from where aircraft could take off with a regular payload. Second, though China had prevailed on the USSR to delay the supply of MiG-21s to India, they themselves did not have any. Third, the IB hadn't taken into account the actual performance of the PLAAF in combat, especially when it had run into US-equipped Chinese National Air Force planes operating over Amoy, Shanghai and Canton. Lastly, the IAF, though numerically inferior to the PLAAF, was equipped with quite an impressive array of aircraft—the Hawker Siddeley